

The Healthy Skin Project Presents:

**Your skin
has questions about acne.**

We have answers.

Quick disclaimer.

We are not doctors.

We won't diagnose you or tell you what to take.

What we will do:

- Give you accurate info about acne
- Help you know when to get real help
- Point you away from bad advice online

Five questions. That's the whole talk.

01

Is it acne?

04

How do I fix it?

02

What causes it?

05

Who do I see?

03

What about the scarring?

*“Healthy skin shouldn't
be a years-long mystery.”*

The help existed. I just didn't know where to look.

Not all breakouts are the same.

NO-VISIBLE REDNESS

Whiteheads

Blackheads

VISIBLE REDNESS

Pustules

Nodules

Cysts

Acne with NO-VISIBLE REDNESS

Pores clogged with dead skin and oil

Whiteheads

(closed comedones)

Small, subtle, skin-colored bumps with no visible opening.



Blackheads

(open comedones)

Pores are opened and filled with debris. Exposure to air turns them black.



Acne with **VISIBLE REDNESS**

Your immune system is now fighting back!

Papules

Red bumps, typically 1 to 5 mm.



Pustules

Papules containing white pus.



Nodules/Cysts

Deep, inflamed, tender, and hardened lesions. Cysts are deeper and filled with pus and bloody fluid.



What's Actually Behind The Breakouts

Clogged Pores
(how acne starts)

Dead skin cells don't shed properly and instead stick together, forming a **tiny plug** that blocks the pore. This is the first step of acne (called a **microcomedo**) → **EXACT CAUSE UNKNOWN**

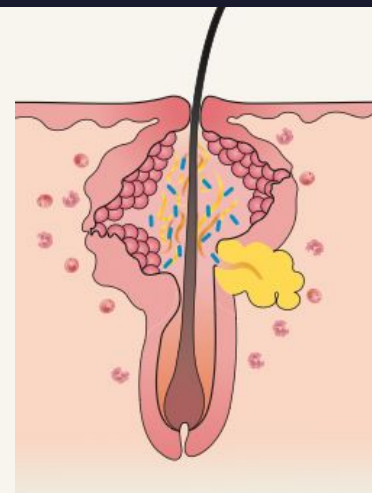
Too much or wrong type of oil (sebum)

Your skin makes **extra oil** that mixes with **dead skin cells**, clogging pores and creating the ideal conditions for **acne-causing bacteria** to thrive.

Triggered by: **HORMONES, GENETICS, ETC.**

Body responds to too much bacteria (C. Acnes)

Bacteria grow in clogged pores to an **unhealthy level**. Your body reacts, causing **redness** and **swelling**—AKA **INFLAMED PIMPLES**

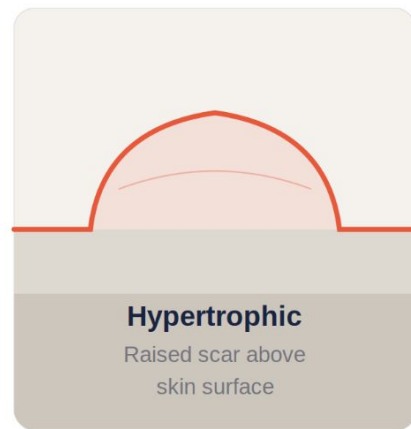
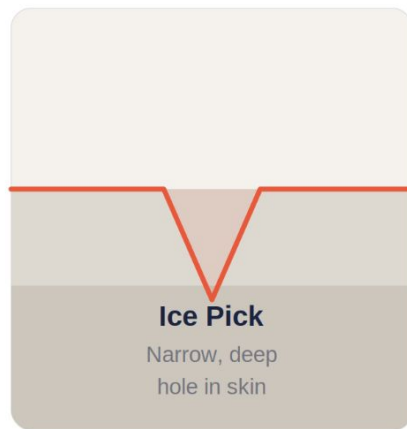
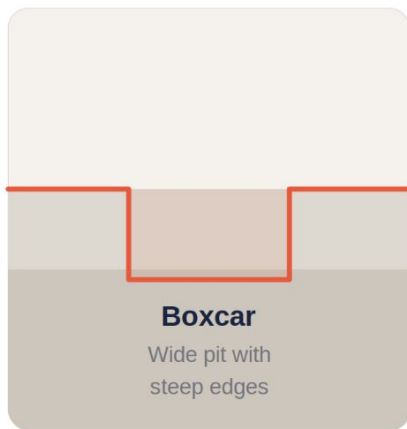
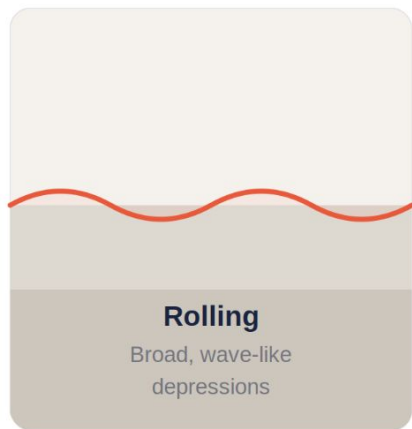


-  Corneocyte
-  Sebum
-  *C. acnes*

Some marks outlast the breakout.

How To Prevent It

- Treat early
- Never pick, pop, or scratch
- **Stop touching your acne**



Things the internet got wrong.

✗ Wash more → clear skin

Over-washing can strip your barrier and trigger more oil.

✗ Dry it out

Skin needs moisture. Drying it causes more oil production.

✗ Acne is caused by dirty skin

Acne isn't dirt. Scrubbing harder strips away your barrier and makes things worse

✗ Toothpaste spot treatment

It's an irritant.

Five things that you can do now.

- 1 Cleanse with a gentle cleanser, twice a day — no scrubbing (can aggravate your acne)
- 2 Clean pillowcases and sheets often (This can help prevent acne but not get rid of it)
- 3 Look for over-the-counter cleansers, creams or gels with **benzoyl peroxide** or **salicylic acid**
- 4 Use oil-free products if you wear makeup. Look for non-comedogenic products
- 5 Apply sunscreen daily! Skin is more sensitive to UV rays when you use acne treatment products

Here's What We Heard

“

I thought I
just had to
wait it out

- Interview Participant

“

I had no idea I
could see a
dermatologist
for acne

- Interview Participant

“

I thought
what I could
buy was good
enough

- Interview Participant

Interviews From People with Acne

You don't have to tough it out.

If mild acne (<15 papules and pustules)

1. You can try over-the-counter skin care products (cleansers, serums, moisturizers)

TIP: ASK A PHARMACIST FOR ADVICE

2. You can ask your family doctor for advice

If >15 papules and pustules or nodules/cysts

Consider speaking to your family doctor or a dermatologist

What to say to your doctor:

"I've had acne for a while, I've tried over-the-counter products, and they haven't helped. Can we talk about treatment options?"

It's not just your skin.

Acne affects confidence, social life, and mental health in ways that are real and significant, not dramatic, not vain.

Seeking help isn't vanity. It's self-care.

Now what?

→ **Consult with a Dermatologist**

→ **Visit our website**



→ **Visit the Acne and Rosacea society of Canada**

